

PORTS



HALDIA PORT

Location: West Bengal
Date of approval: April 2000
Delay: 66 months

COCHIN PORT

Location: Kerala
Date of approval: April 2000
Delay: 44 months

MORMUGAO PORT CONNECTIVITY PROJECT

Location: Goa
Date of approval: March 1998
Delay: 94 months

KANDLA PORT PROJECT FOR CRUDE OIL HANDLING

Location: Gujarat
Date of approval: March 1999
Delay: 48 months

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU PORT (PHASE II)

Location: Maharashtra
Date of approval: April 2000
Delay: 29 months



SHAMIK



Was too engrossed in Sethusamudram to pay attention to projects languishing for years

T.R. BAALU, Former shipping & surface transport minister

1990s, while some have been hanging since 1984. The Government will have to spend about Rs 39,000 crore more due to the delay in commissioning of almost half of the Central projects costing Rs 20 crore and above, according to Minister of Statistics and Programme Implementation Sripakash Jaiswal. This despite a slew of special committees set up since 2004 just to ensure time-bound creation of world class infrastructure.

Of course, project overruns are business as usual in a country where timely delivery of anything is an exception rather than the rule. But these are increasingly under close scrutiny now that India is looking at a quantum jump in the development of infra-

structure and increasing related spending from 4 to 9 per cent of GDP. If these projects are completed on time, they will act as a stimulus to growth by cutting down the rural-urban gap, bringing agriculture and industry closer to each other and generating prosperity. Adequate, cost-effective and quality infrastructure delivered without delay is the best way to beat the meltdown that has pulled India's growth back to 6.5 per cent from 9 per cent, says Gajendra Haldea, adviser, Planning Commission.

That, however, can only happen when attitudes change, says Haldea who blames the resistance from bureaucracy for the delays in meeting project deadlines. "Babus running a

fiefdom, exercising controls over approvals and processes related to infrastructure projects are loath to let go," rues Haldea. He is not exaggerating. In the National Highways Authority of India, for instance, projects falling under public-private partnerships (PPP) are handled by engineers who can devote little time to such projects after handling cash contracts for 10 hours. These PPPs involve big companies, big money, and demand careful attention to structuring of projects. All this needs a dedicated staff to handle matters, but there is no effort to build the strength. No wonder, as Haldea says, projects lag behind.

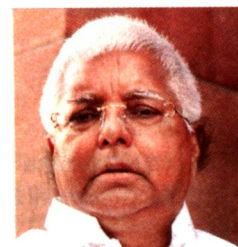
It is not just the babus and their archaic mindsets. The Government has

RAJKOT-VERAVAL-SOMNATH SECTION
Location: Gujarat
Date of approval: April 1992
Delay: 161 months

RUPSA-BANGRIPOSI SECTION
Location: Orissa
Date of approval: Feb 1996
Delay: 144 months

AMBALA-MORADABAD SECTION
Location: Northern Region
Date of approval: March 1993
Delay: 132 months

Despite claims of turning around the railways through his five-year tenure, he failed to push these projects through



LALU PRASAD YADAV, Former railway minister